

“Show and Tell”

Everett Richards

9/15/26

This summer, when I worked at a summer camp, I was asked to bring in a personal item to the staff training to showcase an important part of my personality. I chose to bring in a taxidermied alligator head, which I had purchased a couple months prior to commemorate my spontaneous spring break trip to New Orleans. I told my coworkers that it represented my eagerness to explore and to see the world. And it did.

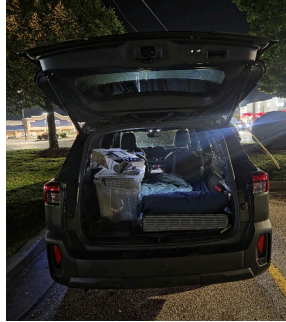


I don't know if—or when—I'll ever be asked to bring in a “Show and Tell” item again in my life. But if I do, I know what I will bring: my little green Bible.

I'm not a religious man. I never was. And, as Jim Croce sang in his melancholy romance song *Lover's Cross*: “I ain't 'bout to start nothin' new.” But this Bible means so much more to me than just religion.

In August of 2026, I moved to Newark, Delaware and bought my first car. I had about a week to kill before my graduate student orientation, so I figured I'd take my deep-emerald-green-pearl Subaru Outback out for a ride. I drove, and drove, and drove—after five minutes I had already left Delaware, by sunset I had crossed the entire state of Maryland, and by midnight I was curled up in the back seat while parked in a Cracker Barrel parking lot in Charleston, West Virginia.

Around six in the morning, a rainbow-sherbet sunrise slowly crawled above the bumpy Appalachian horizon, scattering its pristine light across the humid sky. As an unpaid guest at such a fine establishment, I did the polite thing and went inside to buy myself a meal.



When I sleepily stumbled inside, the crew was still opening up the store, just as the sun did to the sky. When I asked if they were open, the hostess told me it would be about ten minutes 'til she could seat me. "No problem," I said. An elderly woman asked the same question, and got the same answer.

I asked her name. "Beverly." I told her mine.

How strange it was to meet someone so gorgeously plain in such an impoverished state, only to find out that she shared a name with one of the most glamorous, extravagant, ultra-rich neighborhoods in the country. She shared, too, a strange irony with the gold-plated statehouse that gleamed greedily just across the river.

Naturally, we made small talk.

...

After ten minutes of wandering around the gift shop and pretending I was interested in buying something, I returned to the host's podium to claim my throne. A different woman stood behind it this time. She cheerfully guided me to my table, and Beverly to hers – right across from mine.

I ordered a latte. “Foo-foo coffee,” as my dad would say. The waitress asked if I wanted whipped cream. “Of course!” My answer to that question was always the same. But what should I get to eat?

I asked Beverly, the resident expert. She recommended that I order the “Momma’s Pancake Breakfast” with pecans mixed in, “if that’s your kind of thing.”

It was, and so I did.

As we waited for our food, we talked about life. She said she grew up in Charleston, moved away to Florida for about a decade, and then came back to West Virginia after the divorce. She told me she was seventy-nine years old. I told her about how I had just moved to Delaware to start my PhD, and I wanted to drive around to “see something new.”

She told me that Charleston wasn’t exactly at the top of most peoples’ bucket lists.

I am not most people.

...

By the time the waitress came by to replace my dwindled latte with black drip coffee, the conversation had moved to religion. Beverly asked me if I was religious. I told her I wasn’t. “God bless your soul.” I smiled awkwardly. God bless my soul.

...

I finished up my meal (the pecans were an excellent choice!), and Beverly finished hers, and we both walked up to the counter to pay. She reached for her wallet and began counting bills when I interjected, “Can I pay for your meal?”

She humbly accepted, and I settled our tabs. Then, Beverly told me that she had something in her car that she had been waiting to give to the right person—and she decided that I was that person. My ears perked up with curiosity. I followed her to her car.

She unlocked her mid-twenty-tens Ford sedan and shuffled through the glovebox before revealing a small green book. The *New Testament*. I thanked her. We embraced. She wished me luck. I wished her the same. And then I turned around to walk to my car.

I don't know how long she had that Bible in her glovebox. I don't know how many miles it faithfully traveled by her side. I don't know where she got it, or how long it would have remained there if she hadn't given it to me. She might have ditched it the next day. She might have found a new home for it in a year or two. Or it might never have seen the sunlight again until her next-of-kin rummaged through that dusty Focus on the week of her funeral. But I know where it is now.

...

I don't know where Beverly is today, I don't know how she's doing, and I don't know who else might remember her after she's gone. But I know that I will.

